

Louder Than Silence: The Crisis and Resilience of Afghan Women

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Informational Brief

Meryl Streep, a Hollywood actress, once said, “Today, in Kabul, a female cat has more freedom than a woman. A cat may sit on her front stoop and feel the sun on her face. She may chase a squirrel into the park. A squirrel has more rights than a girl in Afghanistan today, because the public parks have been closed to women and girls by the Taliban,” during a United Nations General Assembly event.

This statement is, in fact, the harsh reality of the world that the women and girls have to face in Afghanistan. They are forced to wear a burqa, a clothing item that covers a woman’s entire body and only has a mesh opening for the eyes, whenever they step outside of their home. They are forbidden from speaking in public, as if they were to be invisible. Women cannot travel, work, or access public parks or medical care without being accompanied by their husband or other male relative.

Afghanistan is the only country where girls are banned from having a formal education. They are denied from attending school beyond sixth grade and are forbidden from universities. Once they hit puberty, their family arranges a marriage for them. They use girls as a form of currency, by marrying them in exchange for money. These girls are far from the age of marriage and they are forced to marry someone who may be twice their age. Some girls as young as ten are married to men who are fifty years old.

However, these laws have not always been put in place. During the early reforms (1919-1929), King Amullah and Queen Soraya Tarzi brought radical reforms, such as the right to vote, opening the first girls’ school, funding new universities, and the end of wearing the burqa. Unfortunately, these reforms were removed after Amanullah deposed and King Zahir Shah took his place.

During the reign of King Zahir Shah, women achieved societal freedom, which was considered the Golden Age (1950s-1970s). During this era, gender segregation was abolished and the 1964 Constitution allowed women to vote, run for office, and work as professionals, doctors, and judges. In 1965, Aziza Garadazi and Homeira Seljuqi were appointed as the first female senators. This progressive era ended once the civil war started.

As the Communist Era (1978-1996) started, the Soviet-backed government promoted education for women, but widespread conflict led to severe violence and the erosion of rural rights. When the Mujahideen, militants who fight to defend their religion and community against non-islamic or oppressive forces, took over in 1992, a civil war broke out. This war caused women to face severe new restrictions on their movement.

During the period of 1996 to 2001, the Taliban first came into rule and started enforcing very strict laws. These laws banned women from employment, education, severely restricted from the freedom of movement, and made the burqa mandatory. These laws were enforced until the Taliban declined.

After the fall of the Taliban, which was considered the Democratic Era, the new 2004 Constitution guaranteed women's rights, reserving 25% of parliament seats for women. Girls were allowed to return to school, universities, and the workforce, becoming a visible and active part of the public, political, and cultural part of life until the Taliban regained power in August 2021.

Ever since the Taliban returned, women and girls have been restricted from their human rights. They have to follow those strict laws or they run the risk of getting killed or imprisoned. A clear example of the punishments is from a short film called *Burqa City*, which is directed by Fabrice Bracq. In the film, a woman was walking in a store and greeted the shopkeeper without any male guardian with her. However, the shopkeeper followed her and blew a whistle, signaling the police. She was arrested on the spot, despite the fact that she was fully covered. Even though this example is from a brief movie, it holds the very true consequences that these women must accept.

Regardless of these consequences, these women and Islamic democrats are actively protesting and demanding for their human rights. Some of these protests include marches, defying the dress codes, and targeting the Taliban. Some protesters have used creative tactics, such as writing songs.

In October 2002, a band of three anonymous women in Afghanistan, the Burka Band, wrote a song called *Burka Blue*. The song was an indie rock song that discussed the troubles of wearing the burqa. The song became so popular that it gained attention from all around the world. It helped spread awareness on the problem and is still used as an example today.

The Taliban, however, has been taking drastic measures to prevent and stop these protests. Many activists have been arrested, harassed, killed, tortured, kidnapped, and assaulted during these protests. But, they choose not to let these actions continue to silence them. They are determined to fight until these laws are abolished for good.

To conclude, women and girls in Afghanistan are in a time of crises. They have been stripped of their human rights and silenced. Their protests are getting stronger day by day, with the help of more people spreading awareness. The fight still continues to this day and will not stop until equality is achieved.

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